positively offensive posture involving punitive expeditions not only in British administered areas but also tribal areas that until then had been strictly off limits. There were a series of expeditions—against the Daflas and the Aka Hill Group in NEFA, the Lushai Expeditions against the Mizos, the annexation of Manipur in 1891, the Chinglong-Naga expedition in 1910-11, and the Kuki Rising between 1917 and 1919. The force also distinguished itself during World War I. This is when its name was finally changed and it began to be known as the Assam Rifles. During World War II, despite the reverses suffered in Burma against the Japanese, the men distinguished themselves, especially during the evacuation of civilians from Burma and subsequently as the secret V-Force that operated behind enemy lines. At the time of independence, the Assam Rifles had a track record that undisputedly made it one of the finest paramilitary forces in the world. For the new Indian government, it was perhaps the only real link between the rest of the subcontinent and the Northeast.

THE SWORD ARM

After the first Burmese War resulted in the annexation of Assam, the British extended their administration up to the foothills all the way from Bengal to Burma. The area to the north, reaching up to the Himalayan watershed, would come to be known as the North East Frontier Agency (NEFA) and was generally referred to as the ‘un-administered’ part of Assam, the affairs of individual regions being left to the local tribal people.

To the extreme west lay the kingdoms of Sikkim and Bhutan. From the British point of view, the fate of both these semi-isolated Himalayan kingdoms was linked to two major factors: the fallout of the Anglo-Gorkha wars and the degree of trade that would eventually exist with the Tibetans over the established Silk Route. Sikkim being physically closer to Nepal and the proximity of the Chogyals to Tibet resulted in a fair amount of interaction with the British. Bhutan, on the other hand, not only controlled parts of Sikkim and Kalimpong, it shared its southeastern boundary with the Ahom kingdom’s northwestern border. At the time of the annexation, there had been a degree of confusion and some Bhutanese settlements had spilled into Assamese territory.

Pushing the intruders back was an immediate priority, adding to the somewhat frosty relationship that existed between the Bhutanese and the British. In 1837 and then again in 1863, missions were sent to Punaka, the